Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 24-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at:
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- `word` - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- `WORD` - whitespace-delimited
- `Ctrl-c` - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- `Alt-c` - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- `␣c` is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars `<regex>`, `<file>` and `<ch>` represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- `␣ <minus>`, and `<under>` used for clarity. `<enter>`, `<del>`, `<bksp>`, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

```
.  – any character
*  – zero or more
+  – one or more
?  – zero or one / lazy match
^  – start of line / negation in class
$  – end of line
(  ) – capture group
[  ] – character class
{  } – repetition count
|  – alternation
\  – escape character itself
```

1.4 Launching

- `helix`
- `helix <file>`
- `helix <file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- `helix <directory>`
- `helix -help`
- `hx in some distributions or by alias`

1.5 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

```
v3wd – enter select mode, select 3 words, delete
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

```
      u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree
                history
  :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by
                step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
  <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
        Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.1.1 Quit

Add ! suffix to force operation.

```
   :wq – write current buffer and quit
:wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
   :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
     :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.1.2 Files

```
   :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
  :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>
 :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
 :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
       ␣mf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
             horizontal split
       ␣mF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in
             vertical split
        gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url
             under selection.
        ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
        ␣F – open file picker at current working
             directory
        ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
  <enter> – open selected in current view
  Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
  Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.1.3 Buffers

Add ! suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
     :n – create new scratch buffer
    :bc – close current buffer
   :bca – close all buffers
   :bco – close all but current buffer
    :bn – next buffer
    ␣b – open buffer picker
    ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
    gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
    gn – go to next buffer
    gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
␣wns / ␣wnv  – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
       ␣wq  – close current split
       ␣wo  – close all but current split
       ␣ww  – next split
␣wh/j/k/l   – move to buffer left / up / down / right
␣wH/J/K/L   – swap split with buffer on left / up / down /
              right
       ␣wt  – transpose split
```

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with `z` prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
       Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
  zz, zc – align to center
      zt – align to top
      zb – align to bottom
      zm – align to middle horizontally
      zj – scroll down
      zk – scroll up
```

2.1.5 Help

```
   :tutor – open tutorial
       ␣? – open command palette
```

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
     h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
       gh, gl – beginning of line
     <nn>gl – column <nn>
         gi – end of line
         gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
         ge – bottom of file
         gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to
              word
         g. – to last modification in current file
         gj – down textual line
         gk – up textual line
         gs – first non-white-space char
         gt – top of screen
         gc – middle of screen
         gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
gd – go to definition
gy – go to type definition
gr – go to references
gi – go to implementation

]d – next diagnostic
[d – prior diagnostic
]D – last diagnostic
[D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change

 Alt-e – move to end of parent node in syntax tree
 Alt-b – move to start of parent node in syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
       % – select whole file
  Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
  Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor at
          end)
  Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
  Alt-i – shrink selection
      ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside the object
                  indicated by <ch> below:
      w / W – word / WORD
          p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc. – specified surround pairs
          m – closest surround pair
          f – function
          t – type or class
          a – argument/parameter
          c – comment
          T – test
          g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / WORD
e / E – to end of current word / WORD
b / B – to start of current word / WORD
    x – current line, extend by line
    X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
   ]p – to next paragraph
   [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax node
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
Alt-p – select previous sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax tree
Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
   Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
      v – toggle select mode
    Esc – return to normal
      ) – cycle primary selection forward
      ( – cycle primary selection backward
  Alt-,   – remove primary selection
```

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
s<regex> – matches become selections
       S – split on match
  Alt-s – split on newlines
C / Alt-C – add selection below / above
```

2.5.2 Operations

```
          & – align on primary cursor
Alt--<minus> – merge selections
Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selections
          , – remove all except primary selection
     Alt-,  – remove primary selection
     ( / )  – rotate primary backwards / forwards
Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backward / forward
          K – keep selections matching the regex
    Alt-K – remove selections matching the regex
```

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

```
      i – before selection
      a – after selection
      I – at start of line
      A – at end of line
      o – add line and insert below cursor
      O – add line and insert above cursor
    Esc – end insert (return to normal)
      . – repeat last insert
```

2.6.2 Add

```
   ]␣ – newline below
   [␣ – newline above
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.3 Delete

```
      d – selection -> yank buf, delete selection
  Alt-d – delete, no save
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
```

2.6.4 Change

```
      c – selection -> yank buf, change selection
  Alt-c – change, no save
      = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.6.5 Indent Lines

```
> – Indent line(s) containing selection
< – Undent line(s) containing selection
```

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
      ~ – change case
      ` – set lowercase
  Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
   ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
         ␣C – Toggle block comment
   ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

```
Ctrl-a – increment the selected number
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number
```

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

```
       J – join lines in a selection
  Alt-J – join lines inside selection and select
          the inserted space
  <under> – trim whitespace from selection
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <width>, default 80
   :sort – sort ranges in selection
  :format – format file using external formatter /
            language server
```

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
      y – selection -> yank buf
      p – paste yank buf after the cursor
      P – paste yank buf before the cursor
   ␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
   ␣Y – yank main selection -> system clipboard
␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before selection(s)
      ␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
  r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
      R – replace selection with yank buf
      " – select register to yank to or paste from
```

2.8 Search

```
  /<regex> – search forward for regex
 ?<regex> – search backward for regex
    n, N – next, previous match
       * – search for current selection, respect word
           boundaries
   Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
  "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
    ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
      mm – go to matching delim
  mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
  ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
  ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
  md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
  Alt-| – ignore output
      ! – insert output before each selection(s)
  Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
      $ – keep selection(s) where command
          returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
   ␣G – debug - experimental
   ␣K – show documentation for item under
        cursor
   ␣s – open document symbol picker
   ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
   ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
   ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
   ␣r – rename symbol
   ␣a – apply code action
   ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under
        cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
   :config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config
                         file
  :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
   ␣' – open last picker
   ␣/ – open global search in workspace folder
        picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                 Ctrl-s – commit undo
                          checkpoint
                 Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                 Ctrl-r – insert a register
                          content
       Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
            Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                 Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                 Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
             Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
            Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line

      <Up>, <Down>, <Left>,– usual meaning but
          <Right>, <PageUp>,  discouraged
<PageDown>, <Home>, <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
          Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
            <enter> – open selected
              <tab> – select next completion item
          <backtab> – select previous completion item
            Alt-b – backward a word
           Ctrl-b – backward a char
            Alt-f – forward a word
           Ctrl-f – forward a char
           Ctrl-e – to prompt end
           Ctrl-a – to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
  Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
           Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
           Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
      <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
       <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
           Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor
                    (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w
                    later)
           Ctrl-p – select previous history
           Ctrl-n – select next history
           Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register
                    selected by following input char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
    <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                  <Home> – to first entry
                   <End> – to last entry
         Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
       Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
             <enter> – open selected
       Alt-<enter> – open selected in the
                     background without
                     closing the picker
                 Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                 Ctrl-v – open vertically
                 Ctrl-t – toggle preview
             Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

```
Ctrl-u – scroll up
Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
       Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
           <enter> – close menu and accept completion
            Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
Alt-p – previous signature
Alt-n – next signature
```